

Passive, Deponency, and Tense: Comments on the Paper by Papangeli and Lavidas*

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Papangeli and Lavidas call attention to certain correlations between Tense and deponency. In this paper, I suggest a possible approach to both passive voice and deponency that takes this observation as central. The analytic morphosyntax characteristic of many passives and deponent constructions is conjectured to reflect absence of T-features: a consequence of object agreement in the case of passive, and of lexical defectiveness in the case of deponents.

1. Introduction

If we consolidate the observations of Papangeli and Lavidas (this volume; P&L) with those of such works as Embick (2000), we can construct the following list of properties associated with deponent verbs in Classical Greek, Modern Greek and Latin:

(1) Deponent verbs

- a. A deponent verb has the morphology and the array of auxiliary verbs otherwise characteristic of passive clauses.
- b. A sentence whose main verb is deponent does not show passive syntax, but behaves syntactically like an active verb.
- c. Untensed forms of deponent verbs show non-passive morphology.
- d. With certain verbs (called *semi-deponent*), deponent behavior is restricted to particular tenses.

An important contribution of P&L's paper is their focus on the surprising link between deponency and tense—properties (1c) and (1d). Nonetheless their discussion leaves the reasons for this link unexplained. Furthermore, their discussion (like the literature as a whole) also leaves unexplained why deponency should exist in the first place. In this note, inspired by P&L's contribution, I suggest a possible new approach to these problems. In this brief commentary, I will not argue particularly assiduously for this approach—merely chart a possibly promising path for further investigation.

* I am grateful to Esther Torrego and Paul Kiparsky for discussion of this commentary, but neither is responsible (nor necessarily in agreement with) its contents.

2. Analyticity and the Feature [pass]

Passive clauses and their deponent cousins are often analytic (periphrastic). The T-features of the sentence are morphologically realized on an auxiliary verb, while the main verb itself shows non-finite, participial morphology. A particularly explicit proposal about the nature of deponency and its relation to analyticity is offered by Embick (2000) (cited by P&L), whose work therefore may serve as a starting point for our discussion.

In Embick's theory, the morphology shared by passive clauses and deponent active clauses is attributed to a feature called [pass] (also invoked by P&L; cf. also Kiparsky 2005), common to the two clause types. Differences between passive clauses and deponent active clauses arise from distinctions in the underlying syntactic location of this feature. Adopting the idea of a *v* whose complement is headed by a "root," Embick makes the following proposal:¹

- (2) a. *v* + [pass] yields a passive verb and passive syntax
 b. root + [pass] yields a deponent verb and active syntax

Because *v* is the locus of external-argument assignment and accusative case, it is reasonable to expect the association of [pass] with *v* to affect both these functions of *v*—hence (2a). When [pass] attaches to a root, by contrast, it is reasonable to expect no effect on the external argument or accusative case, hence (2b).

More generally, Embick's proposal permits any property common to passive clauses and deponent active clauses to be attributed to the mere *presence* of the feature [pass], while any property that distinguishes passives from deponents may be attributed to the feature's *location*. Embick applies this strategy to the distribution of synthetic vs. analytic morphology in the perfect tenses of Latin. With non-deponent verbs, the active forms of the perfect tenses are synthetic, while their passive counterparts are analytic—showing a copula and a participle that agrees with the underlying object, as seen in (3a–b). By contrast, in non-perfect tenses, the passive forms of a non-deponent verb are synthetic, with morphology distinct from that found in the active, as seen in (3c–d).²

- (3) **Non-deponent verbs**
- | | | |
|----|-----------------------|--------------------|
| a. | Perfect active | [synthetic] |
| | am-a-v-i | 'I loved' |
| | am-a-v-it | 'he/she loved' |
| | am-a-v-imus | 'we loved' |

¹ As far as I can tell, Embick's proposal does not actually depend on whether the complement to *v* is a "root" or a more conventionally labeled VP.

² Examples (3) and (4) present a representative sample of forms from a much richer paradigm.

- | | | |
|----|------------------------|---------------------|
| b. | Perfect passive | [analytic] |
| | am-a-t-us/-a sum | ‘I.M/F was loved’ |
| | am-a-t-us/-a est | ‘he/she was loved’ |
| | am-a-t-i/-ae sumus | ‘we.M/F were loved’ |
| c. | Present active | [synthetic] |
| | am-o | ‘I love’ |
| | am-a-t | ‘he/she loves’ |
| | am-a-nt | ‘they love’ |
| d. | Present passive | [synthetic] |
| | am-o-r | ‘I am loved’ |
| | am-a-t-ur | ‘he/she is loved’ |
| | am-a-nt-ur | ‘they are loved’ |

Crucially, deponent verbs behave morphologically in these tenses like the passives of non-deponents. The present of the deponent verb *hortari* ‘encourage’ shows the analytic paradigm from (3b) in the perfect tenses, and the synthetic paradigm from (3d) in non-perfect tenses—despite the fact that the external syntax of the verb is otherwise fully active.

(4) **Deponent verbs**

- | | | |
|----|-----------------------|---------------------|
| a. | Perfect active | [analytic] |
| | hort-a-t-us/-a sum | ‘I.M/F encouraged’ |
| | hort-a-t-us/-a est | ‘he/she encouraged’ |
| | hort-a-t-i/-ae sumus | ‘we.M/F encouraged’ |
| b. | Present active | [synthetic] |
| | hort-o-r | ‘I encourage’ |
| | hort-a-t-ur | ‘he/she encourages’ |
| | hort-a-nt-ur | ‘they encourage’ |

If we follow Embick’s general strategy, the contrast between analytic perfect and synthetic non-perfect that is shared by active deponents and passive non-deponents can be viewed as yet another property linked to the mere presence of [pass], regardless of location.

In the case at hand, Embick proposes that the analytic pattern arises when Root+v has raised to an Asp head, and the resulting Root+v+Asp is then unable to move to Tns. It is the presence of [pass] in the Root+v+Asp complex that blocks such raising, as in (5):

(5) **Restriction on Asp-to-Tns movement**

[Perf]Asp does not move to Tns if it contains [pass].

Crucially, the restriction in (5) is indifferent to the initial location of [pass]. No matter whether [pass] was added first to the root (yielding an active clause with a deponent verb) or whether it was added directly to v (yielding a passive)—once a verbal complex containing [pass] moves to Asp, restriction (5) blocks

movement of this complex to Tns. The absence of movement to Tns in turn forces the use of a copula as a last-resort bearer of the T-features of Tns.

Though this approach neatly separates the common properties of deponents and passives from those properties that distinguish them, it does so at the cost of positing a feature [pass] that has no function elsewhere. The feature [pass] is just a middleman—detectable only by the consequences it is stipulated to have for morphology and head movement. The laws governing its location are devised only to distinguish active from passive syntax in the presence of seemingly passive morphology. Consequently it might be productive to investigate alternative proposals that eliminate this middleman. P&L's observations summarized in (1c) and (1d) make such an investigation particularly attractive. I would like to suggest that a view of passive and deponency that puts P&L's observations front and center, while eliminating [pass], might provide a key to why passive and deponency might exist in the first place.

3. Sketch of an Alternative without [pass]

Let us start by temporarily disregarding the existence of synthetic passive and deponent forms, pretending for the moment that all passive and deponent clauses are analytic. We return to synthetic passives at the end of this commentary.

Pesetsky and Torrego (2007) argued, in agreement with proposals like Chomsky's (1993), but in disagreement with proposals such as Embick's, that verbs may come from the lexicon bearing lexically valued T-features. We suggested further that the following statement describes the relation between these features and the syntactic category we called Tns:³

(6) **T-features required by Tns**

The syntactic element called Tns is lexically unvalued for T (i.e., is $\bar{i}T[]$), and must be valued by the T-features of a lower element.

In a language like English, Latin or Greek, the main verb of a non-periphrastic finite tense receives valued T-features in the lexicon (realized as tense morphology). These get probed by the unvalued T-features of Tns, and the operation Agree takes place, assigning to T of Tns the value already present on the verb.

In Latin or Greek, the participle in an analytic passive construction agrees in ϕ -features (gender, number and case) with the underlying direct object (as does the verb in a synthetic passive construction, where the relevant features are person and number). I would like to suggest a link between the presence of object agreement and the availability of T-features that is crucial to the morphology of passive constructions:

³ This is the category more commonly called T, to which we gave a unique name to avoid confusion with T-features.

(7) **AgrO–T Incompatibility (AgrOTI)**

If V agrees in ϕ -features with its (underlying) object, it may not bear T.

Given (7), if a main verb with object agreement cannot supply Tns with the valued T-features that it needs, some other element situated between Tns and V must do this job—hence the obligatoriness of the copula. A passive verb then might simply be a V whose ϕ -features have probed and agreed with a complement. The need for a helping verb and the absence of tense on V itself would be deducible from (6) and (7). Much the same analysis might hold in English, if we can assume that the English passive also involves object agreement, except that English fails to realize this agreement morphologically.⁴

Furthermore, if the analytic morphology of a passive clause in Latin or Greek is a response to the absence of T on V, we expect to find the same analytic pattern (copula plus participle) *whenever* the main verb is unable to bear T—not only when (7) is responsible for the absence of T-features on V. If a language has a class of defective verbs that are *lexically* unable to bear T under any circumstances, a verb in this class would show the morphology and analytic syntax characteristic of passive clauses—even when used in an otherwise fully active clause. This gives us a characterization of the class of deponent verbs, from which properties (1a–b) follow straightforwardly:

(8) **Deponent verb**

A deponent is a defective verb lexically unable to bear T.

If the use of the copula as a source of valued T for Tns is a last resort, the characterization of deponency in (8) also derives property (1c). If even non-deponent verbs lack tense in certain uses such as the supine, such forms should be found with deponents as well,⁵ as discussed by P&L. Only where T would otherwise be present do we find deponents sharing morphology with specifically passive uses of non-deponents.⁶ Furthermore, a deponent verb will look exactly like a non-deponent active finite verb in any tense where the non-deponent itself does not bear the relevant T features. An example would be the Modern Greek perfect, whose form (as discussed by P&L) is identical for deponents and non-deponents:

⁴ Some other factor must in turn prevent a VP headed by an object-agreeing verb from serving as the complement of the *v* that takes the external argument as its specifier and licenses abstract Case on the complement of V—so as to yield the canonical properties of passive, discussed by Chomsky (1981, chapter 2) and others.

⁵ If future is a form of modality rather than tense, we might maintain the view that it lacks T, despite the traditional designation of the Latin and Greek future as one of the tenses. Likewise, we may regard the so-called present participle as untensed but imperfective. The present/imperfect and perfect/pluperfect oppositions found in finite clauses are absent from the participles.

⁶ Since the distinction between passive/deponent and normal active forms is preserved in the infinitive, Infinitival V must be viewed as T-bearing, as argued by Stowell (1982), Pesetsky (1991), and Pesetsky and Torrego (2001) (but cf. Wurmbrand 2007).

(9) **Modern Greek perfect**

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|----|------------|------------------------------|
| a. | exo grapsi | 'I have written' |
| b. | exo dexti | 'I have accepted' (deponent) |

Finally, the existence of *semi-deponents* is also not unexpected. A semi-deponent is a partially defective verb that is allowed to bear certain values for T, but not others.

4. The Synthetic Forms

Because this picture contains no special feature [pass], there is no notion of “passive morphology” that we might invoke to explain passive and deponent synthetic forms like those in (3d) and (4b). Instead, these apparently synthetic forms must actually be hidden analytic passives. In these tenses, the T-less verb (which would otherwise surface as a participle) has incorporated with a distinct T-bearer (which would otherwise surface as a copula). Thus, in a form like *amatur* ‘he is loved’ or *hortatur* ‘he encourages’, a T-less verb (*ama-*, *horta-*) has incorporated into a tensed, inflected copula, represented by the desinence (e.g. *-t-ur*).⁷ A similar proposal would have to be advanced for comparable Greek forms.

Synthetic passive and deponent verb forms, in this view, differ from their active counterparts in coming from the lexicon without T. The fact that on the surface they bear exponents of tense as suffixes is a consequence of syntactic incorporation of the tenseless V into a tensed copula—contrasting with active non-deponent and other synthetic forms, which are verbs that come from the lexicon already valued for T.

5. Final Disclaimer

In this brief commentary, I expanded on the observations of P&L to suggest a view of passive and deponent forms in which it is the absence of T on V that produces the special morphology usually described as passive, in both passive clauses and active clauses with a deponent verb. If the absence of T may arise either from the presence of object agreement or from lexical defectiveness, the existence of passive and deponency as phenomena is predicted. It is more than obvious that this suggestion leaves many important questions open. Among them is the distinction in Ancient Greek between middle and passive deponents—and the distinction between middle and passive voice more generally. Furthermore, the stipulation linking object agreement to lack of T on V, if true, will require explanation, as will the traditionally central properties of passive mentioned in footnote 5.

⁷ The final *-r* found in all persons of the Latin synthetic passive/deponent except the second person plural might be the copula itself, and the fact that it is preceded rather than followed by tense and person inflection might conceivably be related to the obligatoriness of V-incorporation (which places tense and person marking to the right of a verbal stem, as is otherwise the case in Latin).

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